

WAITING FOR HER WAGE
Arati Das at her home in Bilkanda, North 24 Parganas district

Bengal is Rs 3,732 crore. Add non-wage payments, and the amount doubles to Rs 6,907 crore. The non-payment of wages for the central job scheme has led to massive joblessness, pushed thousands into penury and resulted in large-scale migration out of the state.

The reason behind the Union government's action is the accusation that the state administration has misappropriated NREGS funds. Since July 2021, 16 central teams have visited different districts of Bengal to inquire into the NREGS-related allegations, and are said to have collated evidence of alleged embezzlement, creation of ghost work and workers and other malpractices.

Senior state government officials admit 'mistakes' on their part. However, rectifications were made as per the Centre's instructions, they claim. Action Taken Reports were sent to the Centre, and there have been multiple bureaucrat- and minister-level correspondences. Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee, too, has written to the prime minister. "But we still do not know when the ball will start rolling again", a senior officer in the state panchayat department says.

Not just NREGS, funds under another flagship central scheme—the Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana-Grameen (PMAY-G), which provides funds for affordable housing—have also been frozen amid allegations of widespread corruption against the TMC administration and after a central probe.

POLITICS OVER NREGS

The issue of the stalled NREGS funds and the misery it has caused has been politicised for long. The TMC has blamed the Centre's 'vendetta politics' for the withholding of funds and accused it of an 'economic blockade'; the principal opposition BJP has alleged the situation arose from rampant corruption. Leader of the Opposition in the West Bengal assembly, BJP MLA Suvendu Adhikari, was a prime accuser—he wrote multiple times to Union rural development minister Giriraj Singh in 2022, alleging that fake NREGS job cards were created to "overinflate" the Centre's due and that TMC leaders siphoned off part of the NREGS payments.